Working with Disaster Spiritual Care in Shelters (and Other Service Delivery Sites)

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools

DCS JT Response/Disaster Spiritual Care

Purpose

This job tool supports Shelter Managers and other service delivery site managers and the Disaster Spiritual Care Headquarters Lead on a disaster operation in ensuring that appropriate and respectful disaster spiritual care support is provided to members of the community while maintaining impartiality and neutrality.

Audience

Operations managers, Sheltering Leads, Shelter Managers, shelter workers, the Disaster Spiritual Care Headquarters Lead, and Disaster Spiritual Care staff

Procedures

The Red Cross welcomes faith providers from the community to visit their own parishioners or anyone who requests to consult with them. Try to provide private spaces where people can pray or engage in other types of religious practices with their spiritual advisors.

- Red Cross Disaster Spiritual Care workers who are assigned to a disaster operation have been trained in interfaith work. They are available to provide basic spiritual care services to anyone, regardless of their spiritual or other background.
- Red Cross Disaster Spiritual Care workers are also liaisons to the community and can help connect residents with local faith providers of their choice.
- If a client is in need of a faith provider, check with the Disaster Spiritual Care Lead at Disaster Relief Operation (DRO) Headquarters. It is the Lead's job to maintain resource lists of community organizations of various denominations.
- A Disaster Spiritual Care responder should be assigned to every shelter, although that person may need to itinerate to more than one shelter. If another Disaster Spiritual Care worker would be helpful at a shelter or other service delivery site, please inform a supervisor so a request can be made for a Disaster Spiritual Care worker to be assigned.
- Local faith-based groups or providers may wish to visit with members of their communities. Local faith providers are always welcome to visit individual residents in the shelter.
- If a local group would like to hold religious services for shelter residents, it may do so in a location that will provide privacy and will also respect the needs of shelter residents who do not want to participate in the religious activity. A separate room in the facility or a screened-off space may be a suitable location.
- Some national faith-based partners may also provide services at Red Cross shelters or other service delivery sites. Please consult with the Disaster Spiritual Care Lead at Disaster Operation Headquarters to determine whether a group has been invited or approved to provide services in Red Cross disaster sites.